

2 ESDRAS

THE BOOK OF NEHEMIAS;

commonly called THE SECOND BOOK OF ESDRAS.

PREFACE.

This Book takes its name from the writer, who was cup-bearer to Artaxerxes, (surnamed Longimanus) king of Persia, and was sent by him with a commission to rebuild the walls of Jerusalem. It is also called the Second Book of Esdras, because it is a continuation of the history begun by Esdras, of the state of the people of God after their return from captivity. Ch. ---

Genebrard believes that the latter wrote the work. But how long must he thus have lived? and how come the lists to vary so much? C. --- We may allow that these variations are owing to the mistakes of transcribers, (1 Esd. ii. 1.) for the writer of both works was certainly inspired. Esdras lived a long time along with Nehemias; (C. xii. 35.) and he may have left memorials, as well as the latter, from which the present work seems to be compiled. H. --- Some additions have been made since the days of Nehemias, articularly C. xii. to v. 26, or at least (C.) the five last of these verses. Capel. Chron. --- The passage cited from the commentaries of Nehemias, (2 Mac. ii. 13.) is not to be found here; which shews that we have not his entire work, but only an abridgment, in which the author has adopted his words, with some few alterations. The fifth chapter seems to be out of its place, and also the dedication of the walls. C. xii. 27.

Nehemias was a person in great favour at the court of Persia; and of high birth, probably of the royal family, (Euseb. Isid.

Genebrard in Chron.) as most of the ancients believe that all who governed, till the time of the Asmoneans, were of the tribe of Juda. Hence he styles Hanani his brother, (C. i. 2.) and declines entering into the temple. C. vi. 11. His name never occurs among the priests; and though we read 2 Mac. i. 18. 21, jussit sacerdos Nehemias, (T.) the Greek has, "Nehemias order the priests;"

iereis: (C. Huet. D.) and the title of priest sometimes is given to laymen at the head of affairs.

H. --- In this character Nehemias appeared, by order of Artaxerxes: and notwithstanding the obstructions of the enemies of Juda, rebuilt the walls of Jerusalem, and returned after twelve years to court, making a second visit to his own country, a little before the death of the king, whom he probably survived only one year, dying A. 3580, about thirty years after he had been appointed governor. C. --- In the two first chapters, we behold his solicitude for the welfare of his country, in the ten following his success, and in the last what abuses he corrected. W. --- He renewed the covenant with God, (C. ix. and x.) sent for the sacred fire, and established a library at Jerusalem. 2 Mac. i. 19. 34.

and ii. 13. H.

2 ESDRAS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Words, or transactions written by Nehemias. M. --- Helcias, or Heb. and Sept. "Chelcias."

--- Casleu, the third of the civil year. 1 Esd. x. 9. --- Year of Artaxerxes, (C.) after he was associated with his father on the throne; (T.) or rather the death of Xerxes. From this period the seventy weeks of Daniel are dated, (D.) or from the 23rd of Artaxerxes, and the 28th of Xerxes, (T.) as above three years must have been consumed in making preparations for the walls, &c.

Josephus xi. 5. --- The name of Nehemias, "comforter of God," as well as his being sent by a king to build, &c. prefigured Jesus Christ, sent by God to comfort and establish his Church. Ven.

Bede. W. H. --- Susa. Heb. "in Susa, the palace," where the kings of Persia resided in the months of winter, (Athen. xii. 1.) and of spring. Xenoph. Cyr. viii.

Curt. v. 8. --- Here Darius probably kept his court at other times. Est. i. 2. C. ---

Susa was situated on the river Coaspes, between the provinces of Babylon and Persia. D.

Ver. 2. Hanani, a relation, whom Nehemias brought back. C. vii. 2. --- Came.

Some Latin copies add, "to me," (Lyran) as if a deputation had been sent; but of this the text is silent. C.

Ver. 3. Province of Judea, subject to the Persians, as it was afterwards to the Romans; though, at present, they were allowed to have governors of their own nation. M. --- Reproach, on account of the surrounding enemies. H. --- Fire, recently; (M. See 1 Esd. iv. 12. and xi. 9.) or rather

by Nabuchodonosor; as the kings of Persia would not suffer the city to be fortified, for fear of a fresh rebellion. Lyran. T. --- We find that little progress (C. ii. and iv. C.) had at least been made in the work, though the blame must rather be laid on the enemies of Israel, than on several of the kings of Persia, who seem to have authorized the undertaking, which Cambyses, or Smerdis, had for a time interrupted. They only specify, indeed, that leave was granted to build the temple. But they allowed them to erect houses for themselves, which could not have been done to any purpose, among so many enemies, unless they had been defended by some sort of fortifications.

H.

Ver. 4. Days; about four months, till Nisan. C.

Ver. 6. They. Heb. and Sept. "we have sinned." M.

Ver. 7. Vanity. Heb. "we have been corrupted." Vat. "we have dealt very corruptly." Prot. H. ---

The author of the Vulg. has read e for é. C. --- Sept. "we have been very dissolute, or weak."

Ver. 9. World. Lit. "of heaven, or the sky," (H.) which seems to the vulgar (C.) to rest upon the horizon. T. See Deut. xxx. 4.

Ver. 10. Redeemed, or liberated from great evils. M.

Ver. 11. Man; (virum) the great king, (H.) Artaxerxes. C. --- Cup-bearer; Athersatha. 1 Esd. ii.

63. and 2 Esd. vii. 65.

2 ESDRAS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Year. It seems the Persians began the year with Tizri, since both Casleu (the third) and Nisan (the seventh month of the civil year) fall on the twentieth of the king. --- Wine. These kings drunk only that of Syria. Strabo xv. --- People of distinction were appointed cup-bearers; and even the children of kings did not esteem the office beneath them. Herod. iii. 34. Athen. x.

6. Homer, &c. C. --- I was. Prot. "I had not been before-time sad in his presence." H. --- Heb.

lit. "I was not evil." Sept. "an enemy, or stranger." Arab.
"disagreeable." Syr.

"sorrowful." Sept.

also, "there was not another (ouk en eteros) present," C. v. 6. S. Jerom seems not to have read the negation. H.

Ver. 2. Is not. Heb. "nothing but sorrow of heart;" (Syr. C. Prot.) or rather, thou art meditating only treason. Sept. "This is nothing but wickedness of heart,"

(H.) which often shews itself on the countenance. The king might suspect that he was giving him poison. M. --- Hence Nehemias feared, (C.) dreading such suspicions, (H.) and aware lest the company might frustrate his good design, as contrary to the interests of the crown. T.

Ver. 3. Live; an usual salutation. Dan. iii. 9. and v. 10. So Ælian (var. i. 32.) says,

"O king Artaxerxes, mayst thou reign for ever." --- Father, v. 5. He knew that the Persians shewed great regard to the dead, (C. T.) whose bodies they sometimes cover with wax, and keep in their house, (Cic. Tusc. i. Alex. Genial iii. 2.) or inter. Herod. i. 140.

Ver. 4. Heaven, a fervent ejaculation, in secret, (T.) to touch the king's heart, (C.) and to enable me to speak in a proper manner. M.

Ver. 6. And, &c. In private the queen might dine with her husband, but not in public. Est. i. C.

--- Queen; probably Esther, if she were married to this king. M. --- But this is uncertain. H. ---

Usher thinks it was Damaschia, mentioned by Ctesias. C. --- Time, when I should return. Some king eight or ten years, and returned into Judea towards the end of the reign of Artaxerxes. C.

xiii. 6. C. --- He perhaps asked permission to visit Jerusalem for only a short period, at first, but his presence being deemed necessary, he was permitted to continue there as governor full twelve years. M.

Ver. 7. Over; give me a guard, (H.) or accompany me to Jerusalem. M.

Ver. 8. Forest. Heb. pordes, "paradise," or garden planted with trees. Pliny (v.

23.) mentions a

"paradise," in Coelosyria. Grot. --- But Nehemias might petition to be supplied with cedars from Libanus, (T.) as they had been given for the temple. 1 Esd. iii.

7. H. --- Tower. Heb. bira, means also "a palace or temple." It may designate the porch of the temple, which was 120 cubits high; (2 Par. iii. 4. C.) though that had been lately repaired by Esdras. M. --- Others think the doors of the courts are meant, as they were as strong as those of towers. Vatab. --- They were not yet finished. C. x. 9. Many believe that (C.) Nehemias speaks of the royal palace, which had been almost contiguous to the temple, (M.) where he intended to build one for himself, while he should reside in the city. T. --- But this might give umbrage to the king. C. --- He could not, however, intend his favourite to remain without a suitable palace; and the latter seems to have

designed not only to repair that which Solomon had founded, but also to erect another house for the governor.

H. --- Good hand; favour, (M.) and powerful aid. H.

Ver. 10. Horonite, a native, not (C.) a petty king (Grot.) of Horonaim, in the country of Moab.

Jer. xlviii. 3. He must have been very old, if he lived till the temple was built at Garizim: (Josephus and Scaliger) but Petau supposes that there were two of the name. --- Servant; an officer appointed over the Samaritans, as well as Sanaballat. The Persian monarchs styled all their subjects servants or slaves.

C. --- Grieved. Thus unbelievers repine when any one endeavours to propagate the truth, (H.) or to establish the Church. W.

Ver. 12. Any man, at Jerusalem, (v. 16.) though he had informed the king, v. 8.

H. --- No beast; that none might be alarmed.

Ver. 13. Valley of Cedron, on the east, (C.) or west, near Calvary. M. T.

Dragon. Heb.

Tannin, or "great fish," which might be kept there, unless the fountain was famous for the appearance of some dragon, or the water proceeded from the mouth of a brazen one. Sept. have read thanim, "figs." The fountain of Siloc might have many names. C. --- Viewed. Sept. "I walked upon the wall of Jerusalem, which these men are demolishing or clearing away," &c. H.

Ver. 14. Aqueduct, or reservoir, made by Ezechias. 2 Par. xxxii. 30.

Ver. 15. Torrent of Cedron, having gone round the city. C.

Ver. 16. Magistrates. Sept. "guards." Seganim denotes various officers. C. ---

Work, or to any workmen. H. --- None were now employed. T.

Ver. 18. Hand. God had manifested his goodness and power, at the court of Persia. W.

Ver. 19. Arabian governor. He afterwards accuses Nehemias. C. vi. 6. C.

Ver. 20. Answered. Sept. "returned them an account (logon) ...we are his pure servants, and we will build." H. --- Part, or business. 1 Esd. iv. 4. --- Justice, or right to the city. C. --- You may mind your own affairs. T. --- Remembrance. It was esteemed a high honour to be a citizen of Jerusalem. Ps. lxxxvi. 5.

2 ESDRAS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Priest, the third since the captivity, son (C.) or brother of Joachim.

Lyran. --- Flock-gate, near which was probably the miraculous pool. John v. 2.

But the situation of these gates is not ascertained. --- Sanctified it, beginning the work (C.) with some religious ceremonies. Junius. ---

It was designed to protect God's temple; and therefore, when finished, they dedicated it (W). with solemnity, as they did all the walls. C. xii. 27. The like custom is observed on laying the foundation-stone of our temples. H.

Sanctified may also mean, cleared away the rubbish. Vatab.

T. --- Hundred. Heb. Mea. --- Cubits is not in the original, Sept. or Syriac, (C.) though it seems to be understood. The ancient Jerusalem had twelve principal gates, four east, north, and west.

There were none on the south, where Mount Sion lay. T. --- The priests and others undertook this work, considering their eternal as well as their temporal inheritance. D.

Ver. 6. Old gate, or of the judges, who there assembled. Lyran.

Ver. 7. For the. Heb. "for (C. or) unto the throne of the governor on this side of the river." Prot.

H. --- These people worked near the palace, which had been built for the Persian governor, who came to administer justice, till the time of Esdras. C. v.

15. and 1 Esd. vii. 25. Perhaps the governor of Syria had (H.) assisted the Jews, unless Nehemias himself be meant. M.

Ver. 8. Goldsmith and perfumer, are plural in Heb. --- Left, 400 cubits, (T.) as the wall was not demolished, (M.) having been repaired by Ozias just before the coming of the Chaldees. 2 Par.

xxvi. 9. T. --- Heb. "they pushed forward, (repaired, C. or) paved, (Du Dieu) or fortified Jerusalem unto the broad wall." Prot. --- The Sept. copies vary: some read, they placed, (restored) etheka. Complut. But the Rom. edition has, "they left." D.

Ver. 9. Street. Prot. "of the half part," (H.) belonging to Benjamin. Sellum was the inspector of that part which fell to the share of Juda, v. 12. C. iv. 19.

Grotius. --- Jerusalem, like all great cities, was divided into parts. C.

Ver. 10. House. Thus he would be induced to do the work more perfectly. M.

Ver. 11. Built. Heb. "repaired the other piece," or the part of the wall which corresponded with half a division, as in the following v. 12. 15. 24. &c.

Ver. 12. Alohes, "the enchanter," (C.) as he could perhaps enchant serpents.

Grot. --- Daughters, who forwarded the work, as they had no brothers. M.

Ver. 14. Bethacharam, in the tribe of Benjamin. Jer. vi. 1.

Ver. 15. King's garden. This fountain is mentioned, Isai. viii. 6. Jo. ix. 7. ---

Steps. The place was steep. C. xii. 36.

Ver. 16. Labour, by Ezechias, for a reservoir. 2 Par. xxxii. 4. --- Mighty men of David, (1 Par.

xi. 10.) or the king's guards, (C.) or the garrison. M.

Ver. 17. Ceila, in the tribe of Juda. He inspected the workmen from this place.

Ver. 19. Strong corner, noted for some fortress, tower, (C.) or arsenal. Vatab. D.

--- Sept. "the ascent connecting the corner." H.

Ver. 20. Mount Sion. M. --- Heb. and Sept. "earnestly repaired;" (H.) being indignant at the negligence of his neighbour, or undertaking his work with zeal. C.

Ver. 22. Plains. Sept. "from Chechar," retaining the original term cucar, which means "a plain."

It lay in the environs of Jerusalem. C. xii. 28. --- Of the Jordan, is not in Heb.

&c. C. --- They might be natives of that place. Sa. Vat. M.

Ver. 26. Ophel. A very strong tower. See 2 Par. xxvii. 3. and xxxiii. 14. -- - East of the great court of the temple, from which it was not remote, as Esdras here harangued the people. C. xii.

36. and 3 Esd. viii. 1. Out of the gate was a pond of water, (C.) for the service of the temple. M.

Ver. 28. Horse-gate, by which the king's horses were led to water, at the torrent Cedron. It was near the temple and palace. 4 K. xi. 16. C. --- Some Rabbins assert that people were obliged to alight here, and to go on foot to the temple.

Lyran.

Ver. 29-30. After him, Semaia; as the Sept. &c. intimate; and not (C.) "after me,"

as if Nehemias spoke of himself, as some Heb. copies require. Jun. Grotius. ---

Treasury, or "room." Pagnin. ---

Judgment. Sept. "Maphekad." Heb. mopkod. Prot. "miphkad," (H.) may signify

"command, review," &c. We can only guess at the reason of this appellation. C.

--- Perhaps the cause of the Nathinities were here decided, (M.) as well as those of others. It seems to be the same with the watch-gate, (C. xii. 38.) and led not out of the city, but into the street of the Nathinities. T.

2 ESDRAS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 2. Multitude. Heb. and Sept. "army." C. --- Silly. Lit. "feeble." H. -- Sacrifice, at the dedication. T. --- Day, in so short a time, as their present vigorous proceedings seem to promise, notwithstanding their feeble condition, and the paucity of their numbers. H. --- But no: we shall have time enough to hinder them, (M.) if the nature of their materials do it not for us. H. ---

Raise. Heb. "revive;" a word used for reparations of walls, &c. C. Delrio, adag.

221. --- Sept.

"heal." God's providence did not permit the enemy to rage, till the work was greatly advanced; so infidels laugh at the attempts of your priests to restore religion, which nevertheless flourishes. W.

Ver. 3. Leap over. Heb. Sept. &c. "break down." C. --- Bitter sarcasm, which excites the indignation of Nehemias! T.

Ver. 4. Captivity. Since they have not learnt to commiserate others. C.

Ver. 5. Face. Punish the obstinate. T. --- He does not wish that they may continue impenitent.

C. --- But, on that supposition, he approves of the divine justice, and foretells what will happen.

E. --- Revenge was equally criminal under the old law, as it is at present. But the servants of God express their approbation (C.) of his inscrutable counsels.

The imperative in Heb. is often used for the future tense. H. --- Mocked. Prot.

"provoked thee... before the builders." Sept. omit most of this and the following verses; having only, "Do not hide thyself, with respect to wickedness."

H.

Ver. 6. Thereof, all round; as masons were stationed in different parts, (v. 19.) and not barely on one side of the city. C. --- Tobias alludes to the present lowness of the walls, v. 3. H.

Ver. 8. Together, to the number of 180,000, according to the Jews; who say that they were terrified, at the excommunication pronounced by 300 priests against them, while 300 young men sounded trumpets; and they fled, leaving Nehemias at liberty to continue the work. It is a pity that we have no foundation for this in Scripture. C. See 1 Esd. iv. 3. H. - -- The Samaritans durst not openly attack the Jews, who were under the protection of the Persian monarch. But they endeavoured clandestinely to injure them, (T.) and to prepare ambushes. H.

Ver. 10. Juda. Some of the Jews, (M.) who were dispirited at the greatness of the work and the threats of the enemy. --- Burdens. Sept. "of the enemies."

Arab. "the Jews were strengthened, there were many porters, but they could not finish the work." C. --- Rubbish to be removed. T.

Ver. 12. Ten times, frequently. M. --- Places, among the Cuthites. --- Whence they. Prot. "ye return unto us, they will be upon you. " Heb. the second person is put for the third, which occurs in the Sept. &c. though they refer it to the enemy. "They come up from all places against us." H.

--- De Dieu would translate, "return to us," cultivate the friendship of Sanaballat; or "return home," and leave off this work. The sense of the Vulg. is the most easy, and the best. C.

Ver. 13. Place. Heb. adds, "below." --- Round. Heb. "on the hills." H. --- To remove the apparent contradiction, (C.) Prot. supply, " and on the higher places." Sept. "in lurking holes,"

skepeinois.

Ver. 14. Remember. These are the most powerful arguments to encourage an army. H.

Ver. 16. Their. Heb. "my servants," (M.) half of whom only wrought, while the rest stood guard.

If we adhere to the Vulg. we must suppose that Nehemias altered his first plan, and ordered almost all to be ready to fight or to labour, as occasion might require, v. 17. C. --- In. "Over, (H.) or behind all the family of Juda," (Vatab.) encouraging the people by word, and sometimes by example. T. M.

Ver. 17. Sword. Heb. "dart." C. --- The expression seems to be proverbial. So Ovid makes Canacea speak, "My right hand holds the pen, my left the sword;"

(H.) while I write, I am on the point of killing myself. C.

Dextra tenet calamum, strictum tenet altera ferrum. Ep. Her.

Ver. 18. By me, when the enemy appeared. M.

Ver. 20. For us. Yet we must act with prudence and courage. H.

Ver. 22. Midst. Before they had gone home. C. --- Let us. Prot. "that in the night they may be a guard to us, and labour on the day." H.

Ver. 23. Clothes, even to sleep. --- Only. Sept. Compl. "man and his arms to the water." H. ---

They went armed to fetch water; (Malvenda) or they had their armour and water always at hand.

Junius, &c. --- Heb. "each kept his dart at the water." It may have various senses. C. --- Prot.

agree with the Vulg. " saving that every one put them off for washing" (H.) them, or themselves.

T.

2 ESDRAS 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. Cry. V. Bede (iii. 21.) complains of some pastors who neglect the flock, but exacted revenues. May not the same complaint still be made? W.

Ver. 2. Very. Syr. "and our brethren are too numerous" to find meat. --- For, &c.

Heb. Sept. &c.

"by force." Abenezra, &c. --- Yet most people explain it in the sense of the Vulg.

It was permitted to sell children in extreme distress, Ex. xxi. 7. Grot. C.

Ver. 3. Let us. Prot. "We have mortgaged." --- Famine, or "hunger." H.

Ver. 4. Let us. Sept. Mont. "We have borrowed" on usury, contrary to Ex. xxii.

25. The Jews were still obliged to pay tribute.

Ver. 5. Brethren, who are still in captivity, or we are of the same nature as the rich, (C.) who so cruelly oppress us. M.

Ver. 7. Against them, as a private rebuke would not suffice. T.

Ver. 8. Redeemed, by paying the ransom to the Babylonians, or by using all our endeavours to procure the releasement of our brethren. C. --- For us. Prot. "or shall they be sold unto us?" H.

--- A true pastor practises what he preaches to others. W.

Ver. 11. For them, to the Persian governors, v. 14. H. --- Nehemias remits this pension, which was before paid by the people, and exacted

by the rich.

Wolphius. --- Du Moulin asserts that there is no question of usury, which the Jews always abhorred, much less of that which the Romans called the 100th, (C.) consisting in the payment of 12 per cent, (T.) or one every month.

M. --- Heb. "Give back to them, " (H.) that they may enjoy those things.

Ver. 12. Oath of them. Priests, in private, (M.) who were not innocent; (T.) or these were witnesses of the oath taken by the rich. Piscator.

Ver. 13. Lap, or skirt of my robes. T. --- Such figurative actions were very common. Thus a Roman ambassador at Carthage, folding up his garment, said he brought peace or war. Livy xxi.

18. C. --- Said. Behold how easily was that effected at Jerusalem, which the Romans could never perfectly bring about, after the most violent riots! T.

Ver. 14. Not eat, out of pity for the poor. M. --- He was supported by the king, (C.) or by his own patrimony. H. v. 11.

Ver. 16. Wall, pleading no exemption, but making my servants work. C. ---

Though no particular portion was assigned to him, he helped all. T. --- No land, as I might have done, on advantageous terms. H. --- Rare example of disinterestedness! He praises himself without vanity, only to induce others to follow the same course. So Moses, David, S. Paul, and others acted. Num. xii.

3. &c.

Ver. 17. Men, my brethren, not (C.) Persians. Grot. --- Them; ambassadors. M.

--- If Nehemias behaved with such generosity for twelve years, he must have been very rich; or he received a great pension from the king, or voluntary and abundant contributions from the rich.

Ver. 18. Wines. This was only produced, in abundance, on extraordinary occasions; for the people of the East do not drink wine at every feast. Eccli.

xxxi. 17. C. --- Yearly. Sept.

"Moreover, loaves of extortion I did not seek, because a hard servitude lay upon this people." H.

Ver. 19. Good. A good conscience confidently hopeth for a reward. W.

2 ESDRAS 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 2. Make. Prot. "meet together." H. --- When the adversaries of faith find themselves unable to suppress it, they offer peace: so when Protestants began, and where they are still weak, they would have none persecuted for any opinions in religious matters; "but where they are strong they hardly grant toleration to Catholics." W. --- This has been no where more observable than in these islands, where the spirit of persecution has not yet subsided, though banished from most other countries. See Dr. Milner's 4th let. to a Preb. Debates in Parl. 1810, &c. H. --- Villages.

Most of the Lat. editions, before Sixtus V. read, in vitulis in campo uno, (C.)

"with sacrifices of calves in some one field." H. --- Perhaps Cephirim, (T.) or copirim, "villages," (H.) may be the name of a place in the plain of Ono, (T.) which is styled the valley of craftsmen, (C. xi. 35. C.) in the tribe of Benjamin, near the Jordan. Adrichomius. --- Mischief, by taking or killing. M.

Ver. 3. You. This was one, (H.) though not the principal reason which hindered him. It is often adviseable not to seem to suspect any evil.

Ver. 5-6. Letter. Heb. Sept. and Arab. add, "open:" but this word is not in Syriac.

The letter might be an order to appear, or might be left open to signify that the bearer was a man of confidence, from whom Nehemias might receive any farther information; unless it was sent in this manner out of contempt. ---

Gosseem, the Arabian governor. C. ii. 19. C.

Ver. 7. Prophets. This was false; though, no doubt, the true prophets who lived at that time, would promote the laudable undertakings of

Nehemias. H. --- To counteract their influence, the enemies hired Semaia and Noadias, v. 10 and 14. --- Together, that thou mayst clear thyself; (Vatab.) or that we may repress these rumors, lest the king should suspect us of any connivance.

The first sense appears to be preferable. Nehemias did not take the information as a piece of civility. C. --- The enemies left it ambiguous, whether they would not join their forces with his, in case he meant to revolt. M.

Ver. 9. I. Heb. "Now, O Lord, strengthen my hands; (Jun. &c.) or, "now strengthening my hands, (C.) I went, " &c. Sept. &c. agree with the Vulg. H.

Ver. 10. Went, being invited. T. --- Semaia, of the twenty-third course of priests.

1 Par. xxiv. 18.

M. --- Privately. Heb. "who was shut up," like a recluse, (H.) to deceive the people, by the appearance of superior sanctity, and by an imitation of the true prophets. C. --- Some translate hatsur, "bound by vow," (1 K. xxi. 7.) to protect the governor; (Malvenda) but this seems too far-fetched. C.

Ver. 11. Should. Lit. "Does one like me retire from his post? And who like me shall enter the temple and live?" H. --- It is unlawful for a layman to flee into the part of the temple assigned to the priests. Yet into this he had been invited, as the court of Israel was not perhaps yet secured.

Those who suppose that Nehemias was a priest, say (C.) that he refused to flee, lest he should intimidate the people by his cowardly departure. T. M. ---

Semaia might also have a design upon his life, when they should be alone.

Ver. 12. Understood, by the nature of the suggestion, and the manner in which he heard the refusal. Aggeus, or some of the true prophets, might also inform him, (C.) or a supernatural light irradiated his mind, unless human sagacity sufficed. T. M.

Ver. 13. Sin, by taking any false step, so as to offend the people.

Ver. 14. Prophet. Heb. "the prophetess." C. --- Prot. "My God, think thou upon Tobiah,...and on the prophetess Noadiah."

Ver. 15. Elul, the last of the civil year, corresponding with our August and September, when the walls were dedicated. C. xii. 27. --- Days. Josephus (xi. 5.) says, "two years and three (Greek four) months" (H.) had been spent in perfecting the work. Cajet. --- Others date from the reception of the letter, v. 5.

Vatab. --- But the work only lasted the time here specified, as the materials were at hand, and some of the walls were standing, while the rocks defended other parts; and the city was not then so large as it was afterwards. C. --- The whole people wrought almost day and night, and Nehemias encouraged them with all his power. T. --- Thus Alexander the Great built the walls of New Alexandria, on the Tanais, 60 stadia, or near 6000 paces (C.) long, in less than twenty days; (T.) and Cæsar perfected other works, before Alise, &c. with equal expedition. Bel. Gal. i. and vii. --- The Romans, at the last siege of Jerusalem, surrounded the city with a wall 5000 paces long, and with thirteen towers, in three days. Jos. Bel. vi. 13. C.

Ver. 18. Mosollam, one of the builders. C. iii. 4. M. --- These two powerful men had consequently acted contrary to the laws of God, and the covenant of Esdras, with respect to marriages. They might fear the resentment of the zealous governor. Dangers from false brethren, (2 Cor. xi. 26.) wars without, and fears within, generally assail the servants of God. H.

2 ESDRAS 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 2. House: "the citadel;" (Tigurin) "palace." Vatab. --- The Sept. retain the original, Beria, (H.) which signifies a palace, (Pagnin) concerning which Nehemias had spoken. C. ii. 8. M. ---

But as it was not yet built, the house, being placed alone, more properly signifies the temple. We read of Zacharias and Jehiel, who occupied the same post (C.) as Hananias. 2 Par. xxxv. 8. H. ---

He was next to Eliasib, the high priest. C.

Ver. 3. Sun. Lit. "the heat of the sun," or perfect daylight. H. --- They. Syr. and Arab. "while it was still day," (C.) or the sun shone. Before dusk the gates were shut, to prevent any improper person from entering. H. --- House, on the walls.

C. --- These things protect a city; as grace a guard over the senses, and watchfulness do the soul. W.

Ver. 4. Not built, sufficient for so great a multitude. C. --- They lodged under tents, or in huts.

H.

Ver. 5. Heart, inspired me to provide inhabitants for the city, as was afterwards done by lot. C.

xi. T. --- Written. Hence it seems evident that Nehemias here only transcribes this ancient record, of those who came under Zorobabel, and consequently this chapter sought to agree with 1 Esd. ii.

as well as with 3 Esd. v. 9, (H.) which is now strangely corrupted; so that it can throw no light upon the matter. C. --- Some think that various catalogues were taken, at Babylon, at the first coming to Jerusalem, (M.) and at the dedication of the temple; (T.) and that Nehemias refer to a different one from that of Esdras. Sa. Lucas. T. --- Others suppose that changes were introduced, as the families were increased or diminished, in the time of Nehemias; (T.) who, therefore, judged it necessary to write a fresh catalogue, but only adjusted the old one to the present circumstances, including probably the names of those who had returned with Esdras, or with himself. C. --- This seems contrary to the text, a book of, &c. and it would perhaps be as well to allow that the variations arise from transcribers, as all allow that many of the names and numbers are corrupted. H. --- The similarity of Hebrew letters for different numbers might easily occasion this; as we cannot suppose but Esdras would be able to give the total of sixty particular sums. Watson, let. 5.

Ver. 33. Other Nebo. We find no first mentioned; but in the ancient Latin edition, Nebo occurred instead of Geba, v. 30. See 1 Esd. ii. 29. Sept. and Arab.

omit, "the other." This Nebo may be Nob, or Nobe, in the tribe of Benjamin. C.

Ver. 43. The sons; or, "who were the sons (filiorum) of Oduia." H.

Ver. 65. Athersatha; Nehemias, (C.) as he is called in Chaldee. 1 Esd. ii. 63. M.

Ver. 68. Their. Heb. Rom. Sept. Syr. and Arab. omit this verse; but it is found in the Alex. Sept.

and even in the Rab. Bible, printed at Venice, 1564, as well as in the 1st and 3rd Esdras, (C.) and it is inserted by Protestants. H.

Ver. 69. Hitherto. This is not in the original, or in the other versions. It is inserted in the margin of some Lat. MSS. and entirely omitted in others of great authority. The gloss might have been placed after v. 64. C. --- Yet some of the following verses seem also to be copied from 1 Esdras.

H. --- S. Jerom informs us from what sources the work was compiled, which is all declared canonical by the Church, (W.) whether written by Esdras or by Nehemias. H.

Ver. 70. Athersatha; that is, Nehemias, as appears from C. viii. 9. Either that he was so called at the court of the king of Persia, where he was cup-bearer, or that, as some think, this name signifies governor; and he was at that time governor of Judea. Ch. --- Rom. Sept. insinuates that the princes gave these things "to Nehemias." C. --- Alex. Sept. "They gave for the work, unto Athersatha." --- Prot. "The Tirshatha gave," &c. H. --- Thersa means, "he fed,"

and satha, "he caused to drink." T. --- The A, at the beginning, is only the article. H.

2 ESDRAS 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. Were in, or had been at home, (H.) after the dedication of the walls, (C.) till they assembled (H.) at the beginning of the civil year, on the feast of trumpets, which was a day of rejoicing, (v. 9. Num. xxix. 1.) the festival of the new moon. Riberia. M. --- Gate, near the temple. C. iii. 26. C. --- Moses; the pentateuch. M. --- He is not desired to restore what was lost.

T. --- As many copies had been preserved by the prophets, which Esdras revised. W.

Ver. 2. Women, who were in a separate place. --- Understand, being come to the use of reason.

C.

Ver. 3. In plainly. Prot. "therein, before the street." H. --- Esdras probably read select pieces from Leviticus, &c. but principally from Deuteronomy. M.

Ver. 4. Step. Heb. "wooden tower." C. --- Prot. "pulpit," (H.) made in the form of a cup," (C.) like the cior, or tribune of Solomon. 2 Par. vi. 13. --- Mosollam. We should imagine that this was not the person who had given his daughter in marriage to the son of Tobias. C. vi. 18. H.

Ver. 5. Stood, out of respect, as we do while the gospel is read. See Num. xxiii.

18. C.

Ver. 8. Understood, by those who were near enough, and were skilled in Heb.

(H.) though many began to forget that language; (C. xiii. 24.) and for their benefit, an explanation was given in Chaldee, (v. 9.; Calmet) or Syriac, the vulgar tongue after the captivity. Pure Hebrew was still retained in the public liturgy. T. --- Thus the Catholic Church retains the use of the language first use in the conversion of the respective people, whether Greek, Latin, &c. while she takes care to explain to the people what is necessary, in their own language.

Any change might be attended with more serious inconveniences than benefit.

Our Saviour never blamed this practice, which subsisted among the Jews in his time, no more than that which obliged the people to keep without, while the priest offered incense, &c. Luke i. 10. 21. --- And plainly. Prot. "and gave the sense, and caused them to understand the reading," as much as they were able, though many would, no doubt, still find difficulties, as we at present. H.

Ver. 9. Interpreted. S. Jerom renders the same term, made silence, (v. 7.) as it was the office of the Levites to keep the people in awe, v. 11. C. - -- Prot.

"taught." They had also (H.) to instruct.

1 Esd. viii. 16. M. --- Weep. The Jews had only one feast for mourning, the day of expiation. On all the rest, a holy joy was commended. For the same reason, the Church does not fast on such days. C. --- Law, reflecting on the threats denounced against transgressors, which they had so lately witnessed. T.

Ver. 10. Wine. Heb. and Sept. "things." Syr. and Arab. have simply, "drink." ---

Portions. The Greeks styled them, merides; and the Latins, sportulæ. The custom prevailed not only among the Jews, (Est. ix. 19.) but also among Christians and pagans. Moses frequently exhorts the people to invite the poor; (Deut. xvi. 14.) and S. Paul blames the rich Corinthians, for giving no part of their feast to them. 1 Cor. xi. 21. --- Strength. By this holy joy, we shall be encouraged to perform all our duties. C. --- Sept. "Be not downcast, because he (the Lord) is our strength." H.

Ver. 13. Law, concerning some difficulties, particularly the manner of keeping the ensuing festival. T. --- Thus Christ explained to his disciples what he had spoken to the people. H.

Ver. 15. And that. This is not expressed in the law, though it was probably practised. C. ---

Some translate, "And they proclaimed," &c. Vatable. --- Beautiful. Lit. "very or most beautiful."

H. --- Heb. "of oily wood." Sept. "cypress." Syr. "nut-tree." Others understand the pine, (Pagnin) balm, (Mariana) citron, (H.) or any other species of branches, which might then be used.

C. T.

Ver. 16. House, which was flat. H. --- The tents might be erected in any place; in the open air. T.

Ver. 17. Done so, with such alacrity, though they had displayed more magnificence. See the meaning of similar expressions, 4 K. xxiii. 22. C.

Ver. 18. Assembly. Lit. "the collect." H. --- Heb. "the day of retention;" the people being kept at the temple. C. --- Sept. "the dismissal;" as they were afterwards permitted to depart. H. --- See Lev. xxiii. 26. --- It was probably on this occasion, that the sacred fire was found again; (2 Mac. i.

18. C.) and also the ark, the tabernacle, and the altar of incense, which had been hidden by Jeremias. 2 Mac. ii. 4. Torniel, A. 3610. Cano, &c. - -- But this is not so certain. H. C. Diss.

2 ESDRAS 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 1. Month; Tizri, the day after they had sent away those women, (C.) whose company now covered them with confusion. H. --- They were moved to compunction, by the hearing of the law, read by Esdras. M.

Ver. 2. Stranger; idolatrous women. H. --- True repentance requires the works of mortification, and particularly the removal of all occasions of sin and disorderly pleasures. W. --- The reformation had been commenced under Esdras, but some had relapsed. 1 Esd. x. 3. C. --- The true born Israelites would have no society with the sons of infidels. T. --- Fathers, that they might not be punished for them. Ex. xx. 5. C.

Ver. 3. Stand, to hear the law, out of reverence; (M.) or the Levites ascended the pulpit to read, four times in the day. T. --- After each lecture psalms were sung, (C.) to praise God, and to declare the sins of the people, and their sincere repentance. H. --- On days of mourning, the Jews assembled four times to pray, and thrice on other days, by the institution of Esdras.

Maimonides.

See Acts iii. 1. --- On their fasts, they refrained from all meat, as well as from work, spending their time in prayer. They began at the first hour, and continued their exercises of devotion till the third, when they recommenced for other three hours. They did the like at the sixth and ninth hours; hearing the law, then prostrating themselves to confess their sins. Afterwards they rose to join with the Levites in praising the Lord. C.

Ver. 4. Step, erected by Esdras. C. viii. 4. --- Josue, &c. These Levites are mentioned again, (v.

5.) with some variation. Bani is called Bonni; Sebania, is Hasebnia. C. --
-

Perhaps some of them might be different, as there seems to be no reason for thus changing their names so soon. There are eight persons in both places.

Sept. have, "Jesus and the sons (Bani) of Kadmiel, Sachania, son of Sarabaia, the sons of Chanani, &c.; (5.) and the Levites, Jesus and Kadmiel said, Arise,

&c. (6.) and Esdras said, Thou," &c. H.

Ver. 5. To eternity. Existing. Sa. --- Bless him continually. M. --- Let one generation after another praise his holy name. H.

Ver. 6. Of heavens. The highest, (C.) and most glorious (H.) residence of the Eternal. --- Host.

Stars (C.) and angels, (M.) which are like his guards. --- Life, or being. If the Levites had adopted the sentiments of the Persians, that the stars were animated, this does not prove the truth of that opinion, which has

nevertheless been maintained by many. Gen. i. 18. C. --- The expression is used for preserving, (Ps. xl. 3. M.) re-establishing, &c. C. iv. 2. C.

Ver. 7. The fire of the Chaldees. The city of Ur, in Chaldea, the name of which signifies fire. Or out of the fire of tribulations and temptations, to which he was there exposed. The ancient Rabbins understood this literally, affirming that Abraham was cast into the fire by the idolaters, and brought out by a miracle without any hurt. Ch. --- The Chaldees adored fire, (S. Jer. q. Heb.

in Gen. xi. 31.) and the Persians probably imitated them. Strabo xv. --- The emperor Heraclius destroyed their Pyreia. Suidas. --- S. Jerom translates Ur of the Chaldees, in all other places.

Amama. --- Sept. "the country of," &c. C. --- It is supposed that he sacred fire preserved in this city, gave name to it, (Ur, "fire,") as Heliopolis was so called, from the particular worship of "the sun." H. -- - Abraham, to imply some mystery. Gen. xvii. W. --- See Isai. xliii. 27.

Ver. 10. A name, Glorious, (M.) and to be feared by all. Ex. xiv.

Ver. 14. Sabbath. Which it seems had not been observed by them before, (Ex.

xvi. 23. C.) at least not with such exactitude. H.

Ver. 15. Hand. Promising with an oath, (Gen. xiv. 22. M. and xxii. 16. C.) or displaying thy power. H.

Ver. 17. Their head. Or appointed a leader instead of Moses, (Num. xiv. 4. M.) or an idol. Ex.

xxxii. 1. Sept. "they gave a beginning, or a chief to return." Syr. "their heart returned to their crimes." C. --- Prot. "and in their rebellion appointed a captain to," &c. They turned their back upon the promised land, and set their faces to return into Egypt. H. --- Sinners are not deprived of free-will. W.

Ver. 18. Blasphemies. By attributing the perfections of God to a senseless idol.

Prot. follow the Sept. "provocations." Neatsoth (H.) properly implies words of an insulting nature. C.

Ver. 20. Spirit. The conducting angel. M. --- God enlightened and moved the hearts of the people, by his grace; which he gave in abundance to Moses. C.

Ver. 21. Worn. So as to be sore, (H.) or without shoes. M. See Deut. viii. 4. C. ---

Prot. "their feet swelled not."

Ver. 22. Lots. Heb. "them (the Chanaanites, or as it is more commonly understood, the Israelites,) into corners." C. --- Sept. "by lot they possessed,"

&c. H. --- Sehon was king of Hesebon. Num. xxi. 26. C.

Ver. 24. Land. From which most of their fathers were excluded by death.

Ver. 25. Goodness. Prosperity was their ruin, (H.) as Moses had foretold. Deut.

xxxii. 15. C. ---

"Empire is easily retained by the same arts by which it was procured: but when idleness takes the place of industry, when lust and pride banish continence and equity, fortune is changed with manners." Sallust, Grot.

Ver. 26. Earnestly. Lit. "called to witness" (H.) themselves, (Jos. xxiv. 21.) or heaven and earth.

Deut. iv. 26. and xxx. 19. C. --- Blasphemies. See v. 18. M.

**Ver. 27. Saviours. Josue, (C.) and more particularly the judges, (M.)
David, &c.**

C.

Ver. 28. Rest from their enemies. H. --- The interval between their relapses was very short. C.

Ver. 29. Shoulder. Slipping from under the burden of the law. H. --- It seems this and the following verses chiefly regard the ten tribes, which proudly rebelled against Juda, (C.) and against the Lord. H.

Ver. 30. Years, 254; during which time God had not ceased to recall his people to a sense of their duty, but all in vain.

Ver. 32. Labour. Receive it in satisfaction. C. --- Heb. "let not all the trouble seem little before thee;" as if it were not enough to appease thy anger, when borne with proper dispositions and faith. H. --- Assur. Theglathphalassar, who led some of the tribes into captivity, as Salmanasar did the rest. During this period, the whole nation was involved in misery, (C.) from which they had not been liberated even when the author wrote, v. 36. H. 1 Par. v. 26. M.

Ver. 33. Truth, fulfilled thy promises. We have broken the covenant.

Ver. 36. In it. Tributary to Persia. C. v. 4. and 1 Esd. vii. 24. and ix. 9. C.

Ver. 37. Tribulation. As we cannot enjoy the fruits, being so heavily taxed, and obliged to work in person for the king of a foreign country. C.

Ver. 38. Because. Or "considering all these things," as chastisements due to our transgressions, we are resolved now to reform our conduct, (H.) and to comply more exactly with the covenant, which we will now solemnly renew. A copy was probably deposited in the temple, signed by the princes, (C.) in the name of all. H. --- Malachy (i. 4.) seems to allude to this covenant. C.

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 1. Athersatha. Heb. hatirshatha. Prot. "the tirshatha," cup-bearer, or governor, highly (H.)

"privileged" and honoured by Artaxerxes. W. --- Heb. "And over those who were sealed, (C.

Sept. or who sealed the deed. H.) Nehemias, the cup-bearer." Esdras, Eliasib,

&c. were also princes. C. --- It is not easy to account for the omission of their names. M. --- They may be designated by different titles. An aristocracy, mixed with oligarchy, was the present form of government. The advice of the ancients, and of the people, was taken. C. --- Hachelai, is less properly styled Helchias; (C. i. 1.) where the Sept. read Chelchias, or Achalia, (Heb. chacala) as well as here.

Ver. 8. Priests. All, at least after Nehemias. H.

Ver. 14. Pharos. Many of these are mentioned as returning from Babylon. C. vii.

8. 11. &c.

Ver. 28. Lands. Idolaters, (H.) namely, the proselytes. M. --- Daughters. These did not all subscribe in person, but by the hands of the intelligent, and chief men, (v. 29.) or, (C.) as the Sept.

seem to understand, these went through the different ranks of the people, and received their oaths.

E. M.

Ver. 29. Understand. Heb. mebin, "the teachers," or Levites. 1 Esd. viii. 16. M.

--- Promising.

Heb. "clave to their brethren;" and they promised with a curse to transgressors, and with an oath to walk, &c. H.

Ver. 30. And. In all covenants, the articles which have been chiefly broken, are specified. W.

Ver. 31. Holy day. The contrary practice is therefore sinful. H. --- Year. Not cultivating the land.

Lev. xxv. 4. --- Hand. No debts were to be demanded. Deut. xv. 1. M.

Ver. 32. Third part. About 9 d. (H.) on account of the poverty of the people. C. ---

They afterwards paid half a sicle, or 1 s. 2 d. conformably to the law. Ex. xxx.

13. Mat. xvii. 23. H. ---

Before the captivity, the kings of Juda provided sacrifices, (2 Par. xxxi. 3.) and after, the Persian monarchs supplied what was requisite, in favour of Zorababel and Esdras. C. vi. 8. and vii. 21.

But these grants had been recalled, or were not well executed.

Ver. 34. Wood. The Nathinites had performed this office till the captivity. But not their numbers were too small. C. --- The people therefore brought the wood. The Levites, with the Nathinites, carried it

into the temple, and the priests laid it upon the altars; all being regulated by lots. Lyran.

--- Hence the feast called Xylophoria, was instituted about the month of August, as we may gather from Josephus. The Rabbins say that the priests cut the wood, from March till the 15th of July.

Ver. 35. Every tree, of seven species; the pear, apple, fig, apricot, olive, palm, and vine trees; besides wheat, legumes, &c. C. --- For three years the fruit was deemed unclean. Lev. xix. 23.

M.

Ver. 37. Meats. Heb. "paste." Num. xv. 20. C. and xxiii. 17. --- Ground, or the produce. M.

Ver. 38. With. To observe that all is done according to the law. Num. xviii. 26. C.

2 ESDRAS 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. Lots. Those who had a mind to fix their abode at Jerusalem, received every encouragement. But some were compelled, that the city might regain its ancient splendour, and become the bulwark of the nation. Josephus (xi. 5.) says, that Nehemias built at his own expense houses for the priest and Levites, who chose to reside there.

Ver. 2. Blessed. Applauding their zeal and disinterestedness, as the city was yet only a heap of ruins. C. --- Some from the other ten tribes returned; but the transactions of three tribes are more particularly noticed. V. Bede. W.

Ver. 3. Solomon. See 1 Esdras ii. 55. and 1 Par. ix. 2.

Ver. 4. Benjamin, as well as of Ephraim and Manasses. 1 Par. ix. 3. The difference between this last record and the present, arises from Nehemias including many who returned with Esdras and with himself. C.

Ver. 5. Silonite. Of the son of Sela,. 1 Par. ix. 5. T.

Ver. 9. Second. Vicegerent of Joel, (C.) or commander of a second part of the city. Syr.

Ver. 11. Achitob had the inspection over the Levites and treasures. Eliasib was then pontiff. C.

Ver. 13. Amassai. Or (1 Par. ix. 12.) Maasai, the son of Adiel, the son of Jezra, the son of Mosollam, the son of Mosollamoth, the son of Emmer.

Ver. 14. The mighty, for riches and power; on which account this family was conspicuous.

Ver. 15. Semeia. The ancient Latin MSS. read Sebenia. Martinay.

Ver. 16. Outward. For repairs of the temple, cultivation of the lands given by vow; also to buy provisions, sacred vestments, &c.

Ver. 17. Praise. Master of music. C. --- Heb. "chief to begin the thanksgiving in prayer." Syr.

"leader of the Jews in prayer." H.

Ver. 21. Gaspha, were chiefs of the Nathinites. C. --- Heb. "over the," &c. Ophel was their place of residence. C. iii. 26.

Ver. 22. Overseer. Lit. "bishop." Heb. pekid, which has the same meaning. H. ---

Christians styled him who was at the head, bishop; as the Athenians did their chief justice. Grot. E. C.

Ver. 23. King's. David's, (C. xii. 24,) or perhaps the Persian monarch, who had appointed a maintenance for the priests, &c. 1 Esd. vi. and vii. C. --- Order.

Heb. "that a certain portion should be for the singers, due for every day." Prot.

Ver. 24. People. They addressed themselves to him, (H.) and he gave an exact account to the king (C.) of Persia. M.

Ver. 25. The houses. Heb. "and for the dwellings, (C.) or villages." Pagnin. M. ---

Villages. Lit.

"daughters," which is often used in this sense. H.

Ver. 26. Jesue. This, and many of the other critics, had changed names, or were not built in the time of Josue. C.

Ver. 30. Bersabee. The southern extremity of Juda, (M.) unto the valley on the east of Jerusalem.

Adric. 186.

Ver. 34-35. Lod. Built by Samad. 1 Par. viii. 12. It is called Lod-Hadid. C. vii. 37.

--- Ono had the same founder, and stood in the valley of craftsmen. C. vi. 2, and 1 Par. iv. 14.

Ver. 36. Portions. The Levites dwelt in the cities assigned to these two tribes.

C.

2 ESDRAS 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. Priests. But not all, as some are omitted. See v. 7. 22, &c. --- Josue, or Jesus, the high priest. --- Esdras, the famous scribe, who is supposed to have returned to Babylon, and to have been living under Nehemias, who came to Jerusalem 81 years after Zorobabel. If, therefore, Esdras was only 20 years old at the former period, he must have lived above 100 years, (C.) which is not improbable. Lyran. T. &c. --- He returned again with many of his countrymen, by the king's leave. W.

Ver. 7. Chief. Heads of the 24 great families. 1 Par. xxiv. 18.

Ver. 8. Hymns. To preside over the bands. C. xi. 17. C.

Ver. 9. Office. Heb. "in the watches," each in his turn, (Vatab.) "daily." Sept. M.

Ver. 10. Joacim. These are some of the successors of Josue, (M.) who were high priests till the time of Jeddoa, or Jaddus. W.

Ver. 11. Jonathan, is called Johanan by S. Jerom, (in Dan.) Josephus, &c. ---

Jeddoa. The Jaddus, who went to meet Alexander, in his pontifical attire, and was graciously received by him; as the monarch revered in his person the God of the Hebrews, who had formerly appeared to him in this manner, to encourage him to undertake the conquests of Asia. Josephus xi. 8. --- Some think that the names of Jonathan and Jeddoa, and the v. 22, 23, and 24, have been inserted since the time of Nehemias; as he must have lived 140 years, to see the conquests of Alexander. T.

Petau. N. Alex. T. 2 Dis. 7. --- He could not be less than 20, when he returned in 3550. Jaddus met Alexander in 3672; consequently, at that time, Nehemias was 142 years old. But if he died at the commencement

of the reign of Darius Codomannus 3668, he would still be 138. C. --- Yet this longevity is by no means incredible, v. 1. C. xiii. 28. H. --- Usher (A. 3602) maintains that Johanan was pontiff under Memnon.

Ver. 12. Saraia had given his name to one of the principal families, at the head of which was Maraia, at this time. The Latin MSS. Sept. and Syr. style him Amaria.

Ver. 17. Phelti was chief of two families, (C.) or perhaps the name of the head of Miamin (H.) is lost. Vatable. --- And, is not in Heb. "of Miniamin, of Moadiah, Pittai," Prot. H.

Ver. 19. Jodaia. The same name is written Idaia, v. 6, and 21.

Ver. 22. Persian. Surnamed Codomannus, (H.) Condomanus, (Grot. C.) or Natus, under whom Jaddus was born, though he was pontiff under the former.

Usher, A. 3553.

Ver. 23. Chronicles. Not those which are now extant: but some records which regarded the families of the priests. See 1 Esd. ii. 61. --- The son, or grandson of Eliasib. The author refers to others records, v. 26. C.

Ver. 24. Order. Heb. "ward over-against ward." One company kept guard while another retired.

M.

**Ver. 25. Entrances. These are not distinctly mentioned before. See 1
Par. xxvi.**

15. 17. Ezech. xl.

8. C. --- Sept. have only, after order, or him, v. 25. "When I assembled the door-keepers, (v. 26,) in the days of Joakeim." H.

Ver. 26. Scribe. Could these records have any greater authority than Nehemias himself? It seems, therefore, that this had been added by a later hand, whose testimony is perfectly authentic and inspired. C. --- Nehemias might also refer to some records which he, or some other, had drawn up. H.

Ver. 27. Wall. Some time before, (Usher. C.) or now, when the houses were completed. V.

Bede. T. --- Places, for greater solemnity. The ancients deemed "the walls and gates sacred things, the property of no man." Justinian, l. sacra loca. --- Ovid describes the superstitious rites, with which the Romans laid the foundations of their cities, on some lucky day.

Fossa fit ad solidum, fruges jaciuntur in imâ, &c. Fast. iv.

Ver. 30. Were purified first, that they might purify the rest. H. --- Priests were obliged to abstain from wine, and from their wives, while they were on duty.

See 2 Par. xxix. 34, and xxxv. 2, &c.

Levites were to wash their garments. Lev. viii. 21. All lepers, &c. required a certain purification, ib. v. 2. 6. and Num. xix. 16. Care was taken that no dead body was found on the walls. These were probably sprinkled with water, &c.

like the tabernacle. Lev. viii. 11.

Ver. 31. Choirs. This is not expressed in Heb. and Sept. but must be understood. Prot. "great companies of them that gave thanks. Whereof

one went." H. --- The princes led the way, then the priests sounded the trumpets, (Num. x. 8.) the Levites sung, and were followed by the people. All were divided into two equal parts, and went round half the city. C. --- They set out from the dunghill-gate, on the west, and proceeded to the watch-gate, on the east, v. 38. M.

Ver. 35. Esdras, mentioned v. 33, was the chief personage, at the head of this company. H.

Ver. 37. And, &c. Prot. "And the other company of them that gave thanks." ---

And upon. Heb.

"beyond." This company (H.) proceeded northward. C.

Ver. 38. Watch-gate. Syr. and Arab. "great gate," by which they came down.

Ver. 42. Great. Numerous, or victims of a large size, oxen, &c.

Ver. 43. Thanksgiving. S. Jerom, Sept. and Syr. have read in a different manner from the present Heb. (C.) which has, "for the tithes to gather into them out of the fields of the cities, the portions of (or by) the law assigned to the priests,

&c. Tora, "law," has been read, toda, "thanksgiving,"

by S. Jerom; and sarim, "princes," has been substituted for sadim, "fields." H.

--- The Syriac admits the second reading. C. --- Sept. omit the first entirely. "For the tithes, and for the collections in them, brought to the princes of the cities, being the portions for the priests," &c. H.

Ver. 44. Expiation. Or the legal purifications, (M.) when necessary. H.

Ver. 45. Asaph was master of music in the reign of David. M.

Ver. 46. Sanctified. That is, they gave them that which by the law was set aside, and sanctified for their use. Ch. --- The Levites paid a tithe to the priests, (C. x.

38. and Num. xviii. 26. C.) as the people did to them. W.

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 1. That day, is often used for an indefinite time. H. --- It is not probable that all this happened when the walls were dedicated. After that event, Nehemias rather went to court, and remained there about ten years. During his absence, many abuses crept in, which he endeavoured to remedy, (v. 7.) perhaps on the solemn day of tabernacles, when the law had been read. --- Ever, (Deut. xxiii.

3.) so as to marry. C.

Ver. 3. Stranger. Heb. hereb, "mixture," (H.) infidel women and their offspring.

Ver. 4. Over this things, &c. Or, he was faulty in this thing, or in this kind. Ch.

--- He was the source of all this evil. Heb. "and before this Eliasib," &c. It is probable that he was a different person from the high priest, (Usher) who had married his grandson to the daughter of Sanaballat, the intimate friend of Tobias. C. --- The latter was a persecutor, and prefigured heretics, as Nehemias did our Saviour, who drove traffickers out of the temple. V. Bede in Esd. L. iii.

19. W.

Ver. 5. He. Eliasib, or Tobias. The original is also ambiguous. Eliasib probably permitted Tobias to furnish himself apartments in the temple, where, by law, he was not allowed to enter.

Hence the priests, being deprived of their support, were forced to retire. C. ---

Tobias rented the apartments, and was steward of the priests' revenues. T.

Ver. 6. Days. Prefixed (C. ii. 6.) I asked. Heb. "was required to attend by the king," for about ten years. After which period, I returned and found such disorders. Some believe that Nehemias had been at Babylon, a long while before the 32d year of the king.

Ver. 8. And I. Nehemias acted as governor, and performed the duty which the high priest neglected. C.

Ver. 9. Storehouses, which had been profaned by the presence of a pagan. M.

--- Sacrifice. Heb.

mincha, "offerings of flour, fruits, and liquors," which were kept in the storehouses, as well as frankincense. Eliasib had caused these things to be removed, to make place for Tobias. C.

Ver. 10. Country. Heb. "field," that he might cultivate it, (H.) and get food. M.

Ver. 11. Pleaded. Accusing them of treachery, in not opposing the wicked attempt. --- Have we.

He placed himself in the number of the guilty, in order to soften the reproach.

Sept. &c. C. ---

"Why is the house of God forsaken?" Prot.

Ver. 14. And his. Heb. "its offices," and for the good of the sacred ministers. H.

Ver. 15. Treading. Syr. and Arab. "travelling."

Ver. 16. Tyrians. Who had established themselves there, for the sake of commerce, though the chosen people ought to have kept them at a great distance, for fear of seduction. C.

Ver. 18. Fathers. Though warned by Jeremias, xvii. 21. M.

Ver. 19. At rest. People travelling no longer. C. --- Heb. "shaded, or in the dark."

Before Friday night on, the sabbath commenced, and then the gates were shut.

H. --- On the. Heb. "before the sabbath." M.

Ver. 21. On you. To punish you, (C.) for thus endeavouring to tempt the people.

H.

Ver. 22. Gates. The Levites would more conscientiously discharge their duty, (M.) and restrain the people, so that they might keep the day holy. H.

Ver. 23. Azotus. In the country of the Philistines.

Ver. 24. Half. In the same family, some spoke the Philistine (Vatable) or Phenician language: others the Hebrew; which, though it resembled the other very much, was still sufficiently distinct to be noticed. The children might also speak a jargon, composed of both languages. It is probable that, at this time, many of the common people spoke the Chaldee language, so that it was necessary to interpret pure Hebrew to them. C. viii. 8.

Ver. 25. Curse, or excommunicated them, (C.) the guilty parents. H. --- Shaved.

Heb. and Sept.

"plucked off their hair," by the roots, for greater torment. Sometimes quicklime was then sprinkled on the head, (C.) as adulterers were treated at Athens.

Schol. Aristoph. --- King Artaxerxes changed this punishment, and ordered that his officers should be forbidden to wear the tiara instead. Domitian caused the hair and beard of Apollonius to be shaven. Philost. iii. 14. C.

--- That they. Heb. "Ye shall not," &c.

Ver. 27. Also be. Heb. "hearken unto you;" (Prot. H.) or "Have ye not heard the evils which fell upon our fathers (C.) for doing all?" &c. H.

Ver. 28. One. Manasses, brother of Jaddus. Joseph. xi. 8. --- Sanaballet, noted for his enmity towards the Jews. C. vi. 1. He obtained leave of Alexander to build the famous temple on Garizim, for this son-in-law. He must have been 150 yeas old when Alexander laid siege to Tyre, A. 3672. Esdras and Nehemias were noted for their great age. Yet some would suppose that there were tow of the name of Sanaballet; and Josephus says that the one in question was appointed governor of Samaria by Darius, the last king of the Persians. This opinion is adopted by Usher, A. 3972. T. &c. --- But there is still a difficulty to know whether it be necessary. C. ---

From me. In revenge he set up an opposition altar. H. --- He had contracted a marriage, which was unlawful for all, and entailed degradation upon priests.

Ver. 31. Wood. Conformably to the regulations mentioned, C. x. 34. C. - -- Good.

A just man may confidently beg for a reward. W. --- Amen, is not found in Heb.

&c. The Holy Spirit records the praises of Nehemias. Eccli. xlix. 15. His political and moral virtues must ever assign him an exalted rank among the true Israelites. Like Jesus Christ, he rebuilt Jerusalem, reformed the nation, was the mediator of a new covenant, defended the rights of the priesthood and of all the people. C.